



THE ANDEAN CARAVAN • DAYS 58-71

04

The End of the Road

The Carretera Austral to Villa O'Higgins, then north to Balmaceda and the flight home

A proposal you can picture yourself inside

A caravan is not a race down a route. It is a moving circle — travellers, hosts, vehicles and local knowledge — progressing slowly enough for each place to change the terms.

Section 04 is the last of four sections that tile one continuous 71-day passage from Lima to the end of the Carretera Austral. It begins at the Santiago gate and ends at Balmaceda, where the passage closes with the included flight north to Santiago.

01 23 DAYS	02 16 DAYS	03 18 DAYS	04 14 DAYS	
LIMA	PUNO	SUCRE	SANTIAGO	BALMACEDA
YOUR GATES				
Join at Santiago, leave at Balmaceda. The Day 71 Balmaceda–Santiago flight is planned as included.				

IMPORTANT

This is a route proposal, not yet a confirmed departure.

It communicates the intended route, pace and level of effort. Exact dates, named properties, suppliers, tickets, departure times, prices and meal inclusions become final only after the 2028 operating plan is secured. Weather, permits, border authorities and vessel operators can change the order or content of a day; this guide names those dependencies wherever they affect your choice.

Effort is more than walking distance

Every day separates physical effort from the operating environment. A short day can still be demanding if it sleeps high, begins early, changes hotels or removes access to easy recovery.

PHYSICAL EFFORT

■ LIGHT

Arrival, recovery, buffer or compact programme. The point is to create room around the harder days.

■ STEADY

A normal travelling day: walking, road movement, a visit or a hotel change without concentrated load.

■ DEMANDING

Long movement, significant altitude, rough ground, early start, complex boarding or several load signals together.

OPERATING ENVIRONMENT

CONNECTED

Reliable services and straightforward access to support.

LIMITED SERVICES

Fewer choices and slower access to support; planning matters.

REMOTE

Simple infrastructure, long transfer routes and limited communications or facilities.

FREE TIME

When the guide says free time, it means genuinely uncommitted time. It is not a space waiting to be filled later by a compulsory tour.

The End of the Road

A Patagonian road-and-water passage through Aysén: Cerro Castillo, the Marble Chapels, Cochrane, Tortel and Villa O'Higgins, followed by the necessary return north to the Chile Chico ferry and a closing day in Coyhaique.

HIGHEST POINT

Approx. 1,120 m — survey to confirm

MOVEMENT

Flight, ripio road, small vessels and vehicle ferries

EXIT

Balmaceda–Santiago flight, planned as included

SEASON

Late March to mid-April — Patagonian autumn

THE STAGES

Aysén and the Lake	Days 58–61
Tortel and the Fjord	Days 62–65
The Return and the Ferry	Days 66–71

WHY THE ROAD RETURNS

Villa O'Higgins is the geographic end of the southbound road. The product then retraces north through Cochrane and Puerto Guadal to reach the Chile Chico ferry and Balmaceda. The return is part of the route, not hidden backtracking.

58 Fly into Aysén

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Santiago to Balmaceda to Coyhaique	Coyhaique	Approx. 3 hours flight and 1 hour road	■ Steady · Connected

A morning scheduled flight reaches Balmaceda, followed by the road to Coyhaique. The afternoon remains open for the route briefing, clothing check and rest. Patagonia does not begin with a rushed excursion.

FREE TIME *Most of the afternoon after the operating brief.*

AT THE GATE	The Day 58 briefing serves travellers who have been on the road for 57 days and travellers who arrived last night. It must work for both without making either sit through the other's orientation.
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59 Cerro Castillo to Río Tranquilo

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Coyhaique to Cerro Castillo to Río Tranquilo	Río Tranquilo	Approx. 6 hours elapsed with stops	■ Demanding · Limited services

The road passes Villa Cerro Castillo and continues to Lago General Carrera. Lunch and contained landscape stops replace a park hike on this transfer day. South of Cerro Castillo the road includes ripio and changing surface.

FREE TIME *Only after arrival in Río Tranquilo.*

60 A weather window for the Marble Chapels

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Río Tranquilo	Río Tranquilo	Approx. 90-minute small-vessel navigation	■ Light · Limited services

Morning and afternoon both remain available for the Marble Chapels navigation. Wind chooses the safer window and can cancel it. When the vessel operates, the rest of the day stays free rather than being filled around it.

FREE TIME *The part of the day not used by the sailing.*

WEATHER	Contract a written cancellation outcome and inspect the exact vessel's boarding, handrails, seating, enclosure and toilet provision.
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61 Where the Baker meets the Nef

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Río Tranquilo to Baker and Nef to Cochrane	Cochrane	Approx. 115 km road and optional 2 km return walk	■ Steady · Limited services

The road follows the lake and river country towards Cochrane. An optional path reaches the meeting of the Baker and Nef. A parallel river or local programme for travellers who do not take the path will be planned in advance, not improvised.

FREE TIME *After arrival in Cochrane.*

LAUNDRY	A laundry opportunity is planned here; the next reliable one is expected in Coyhaique on Day 70.
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62 Tortel begins on foot

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Cochrane to Caleta Tortel	Caleta Tortel	Approx. 3 to 3.5 hours road, then boardwalks and stairs	■ Demanding · Remote

The road ends above Caleta Tortel. The village continues through timber boardwalks and stairs — a settlement built from and on cypress, which is the materials thread arriving at the end of the road. Main luggage remains with the vehicle only when secure storage is confirmed.

FREE TIME *A contained afternoon on the boardwalks after arrival.*

ACCESS	Tortel is not step-free. Measure the selected property's actual distance, stairs, gradient, handrails and wet-weather surface. If portorage is unavailable, final departure documents will state the exact guest-carried load.
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63 Cross the Mitchell Fjord

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Tortel to Puerto Yungay to Río Bravo to Villa O'Higgins	Villa O'Higgins	Approx. 4 to 5 hours plus ferry and stops	■ Steady · Remote

An early road departure reaches Puerto Yungay. The free vehicle ferry crosses the Mitchell Fjord to Río Bravo and boards in order of arrival under the current system. The road then continues to Villa O'Higgins. Nothing is fixed in the evening.

FREE TIME *Only after arrival.*

64 First O'Higgins Glacier window

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Villa O'Higgins and Lago O'Higgins	Villa O'Higgins	Planned full-day vessel, currently approx. 7 hours	Light · Remote

The first full day is held for the planned navigation towards the O'Higgins Glacier. Wind and lake conditions decide whether the vessel can depart. Availability is checked against the forecast and the operator's decision.

FREE TIME *The evening after return, or the day if the sailing is moved to Day 65.*

WEATHER	The sailing remains planned and subject to weather. Both Day 64 and Day 65 remain protected as usable windows, with a written remedy if neither operates.
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65 Protected second sailing window

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Villa O'Higgins	Villa O'Higgins	Sailing if deferred, otherwise local	Light · Remote

If the vessel did not sail on Day 64, this day remains clear for a second attempt. If it did, the day becomes a slow local programme: village, end-of-road marker, museum or a short lower trail chosen with local guides.

FREE TIME *Substantial when the glacier sailing has already operated.*

66 Retrace to Cochrane

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Villa O'Higgins to Río Bravo to Puerto Yungay to Cochrane	Cochrane	Approx. 6 to 7 hours road and ferry	■ Demanding · Remote

The route returns through Río Bravo and Puerto Yungay, then retraces the southern road to Cochrane. This repetition is operationally necessary. The different return line begins on the following day.

FREE TIME *None is promised before Cochrane.*

67 Turn east and sleep at Puerto Guadal

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Cochrane to Puerto Bertrand to El Maitén to Puerto Guadal	Puerto Guadal	Road; elapsed time to be measured after Route 265 survey	■ Steady · Limited services

The route retraces from Cochrane through Puerto Bertrand to the El Maitén junction, then turns east on Route 265 and stops at Puerto Guadal for the night. The point of the overnight is not to add another attraction. It is to end the return road before the winding push to Chile Chico.

FREE TIME *After arrival at the lake.*

WHY PUERTO GUADAL	Puerto Guadal is an overnight, not a daytime pause. It breaks the demanding return into a more manageable sequence. Exact movement time, road conditions and property access will be confirmed before departure.
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68 Puerto Guadal to Chile Chico

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Puerto Guadal to Chile Chico	Chile Chico	Route 265 road; elapsed time to be measured	■ Steady · Limited services

The road continues east through Paso Las Llaves towards Chile Chico. It is winding and includes ripio. Lunch and landscape intervals belong inside the movement; no hike is added and no planned driving continues after dark.

FREE TIME *After arrival in Chile Chico.*

69 Ferry to Puerto Ibáñez

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Chile Chico to Puerto Ibáñez to Coyhaique	Coyhaique	Approx. 7 to 8 hours elapsed	■ Demanding · Limited services

The vehicle reports early for the morning Lago General Carrera ferry. The crossing currently takes about two hours, followed by the road from Puerto Ibáñez to Coyhaique. The whole day is protected around the ferry.

FREE TIME *Only after arrival in Coyhaique.*

TIMING

The final itinerary will work backwards from the secured 2028 morning ferry. The operator may change or cancel sailings. This ferry and the Day 23 train are the two anchors of the whole 71-day calendar.

70 Coyhaique buffer and the closing table

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Coyhaique	Coyhaique	None unless recovery is required	■ Light · Connected

The final full day is held first as an operational buffer. If the route has run to schedule, the day belongs to rest, laundry and individual time. In the late afternoon or evening, the Caravan closes with one shared table and a small physical route record or field-note exchange. There is no certificate, speech ritual or forced reflection.

FREE TIME *The whole day until the closing table when the buffer is not used.*

RESILIENT ENDING	If a ferry or road delay consumes Day 70, the closing table is dropped without regret. A short breakfast and route-record handover moves to Day 71 before the airport.
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71 Balmaceda, where the Caravan stops

ROUTE	SLEEP	MOVEMENT	RHYTHM
Coyhaique to Balmaceda Airport	No Caravan night	Approx. 1 hour road	■ Light · Connected

The Caravan travels to Balmaceda for a midday or afternoon onward flight. The Through-Journey Steward remains responsible through the agreed airport handover. Onward international travel from Santiago remains the traveller's arrangement. Sawayatra holds a recommended connection window, a Coyhaique extra-night option and a named person to call.

FREE TIME *Determined by the secured onward flight.*

INCLUDED EXIT FLIGHT	The Balmaceda to Santiago flight is part of every product that closes at Balmaceda. Sawayatra returns travellers to the international gateway rather than dissolving at a regional check-in desk.
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Where this section asks more of you

Ripio, long seated days, three vehicle-ferry crossings on two services and two planned, weather-dependent small-vessel experiences.

Tortel is reached through boardwalks and stairs and is not step-free.

The O'Higgins Glacier sailing and Marble Chapels navigation are weather-dependent and may not operate at all.

Day 66 is followed by two Steady road days before the ferry-heavy Day 69. There is no three-day demanding return cluster.

April accommodation and services are thinner than high summer. Every property must confirm it remains open for the exact dates.

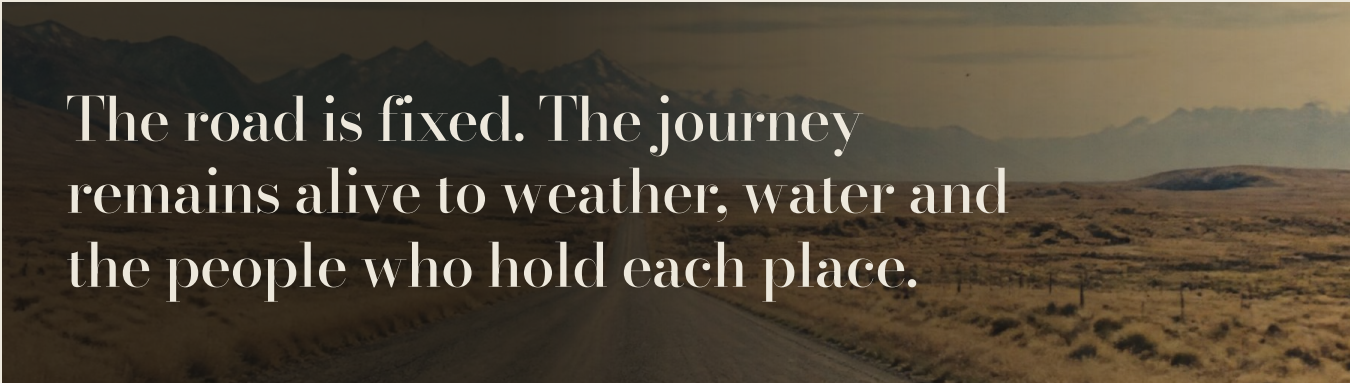
SLEEP PATTERN

Coyhaique three nights across two stops. Río Tranquilo and Villa O'Higgins each hold two or more nights to create weather windows. Cochrane is used in both directions. Puerto Guadal is an overnight. Coyhaique holds the final two nights as the ferry, closure and flight buffer.

From route proposal to your departure

This guide is the clearest picture of the intended journey through The End of the Road. Before this section is offered as a secured departure, Sawayatra will reconcile the calendar, contract the route-critical trains, flights, ferries, refuges and local encounters, inspect access and accommodation, and publish the exact inclusion and cancellation terms.

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| 01 | Choose the passage | One section, consecutive sections, The Stone Road, or the full 71 days. |
| 02 | Discuss readiness | Altitude, walking, access, room basis, luggage and the demands that matter to you. |
| 03 | Receive the secured detail | Dates, price, properties, flights, inclusions, medical and insurance requirements, and the final day plan. |
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The road is fixed. The journey remains alive to weather, water and the people who hold each place.